Wish, Assumption or Promise?

A one-page sheet for sorting what gets said about the future: seventeen plain words, and what to write down for each.

“She'd never want that.” “We'll take care of you.” “I like my mornings quiet.” Three different kinds of sentence, and only one of them is hers. This sheet gives each kind a plain name and says what to write down when you hear it.

The words are for sorting what gets said. They aren't for sizing up your wife, or the family.

What she says

Stated wish

Something your wife has said she wants. If she hasn't said it, it isn't one yet. The Institute for Healthcare Improvement tells care teams to use the person's own words as much as possible when they record what matters. [1]

WRITE DOWN The sentence as she said it, and the date.

Daily priority

A part of her ordinary day or week that matters to her. A federal toolkit on person-centered thinking counts daily rituals, weekly or monthly events such as church or a book club, and occasions such as birthdays and anniversaries. [2]

WRITE DOWN What it is, when it happens and who it's with.

Good day

Her own description of a day that went well. The Conversation Project's starter guide asks it as a question: “What does a good day look like for you?” [3]

WRITE DOWN Her answer, not yours.

What matters

The question care teams are encouraged to ask alongside “What is the matter?” The Institute for Healthcare Improvement's examples are everyday ones, such as walking with friends in the morning or babysitting a grandchild. [1]

WRITE DOWN What she names, even where you'd have guessed differently.

Important to her

A phrase from person-centered planning for the parts of a person's life that help them feel satisfied, content, fulfilled, happy and comforted. [2]

WRITE DOWN Her list, kept apart from anyone else's.

Person-centered

Care that is guided and informed by a person's goals, preferences and values. It's a phrase care professionals use. [4]

WRITE DOWN Whether each line on your page is hers or the family's.

What the family says

Assumption

Something a relative believes she wants that she hasn't said. “She'd never leave this house” is an assumption until she says it.

WRITE DOWN Who believes it, and a note to ask her.

Family concern or hope

A worry or a wish about the years ahead that belongs to a family member, not to your wife. It may match hers or it may not.

WRITE DOWN Whose it is, in their words, on a separate line from hers.

Offer

What a relative says they could actually do: what, how often, and what it depends on.

WRITE DOWN The offer as given, including the “depends on.”

Promise

An offer with no conditions and no end date, like “we'll always take care of you.” It comes easily when nothing is being asked.

WRITE DOWN What was said, and a note to ask what it depends on.

Limit

What a person can't realistically do, or isn't willing to do. The National Institute on Aging says no one can be expected to do everything. [5]

WRITE DOWN Each person's limits as they state them, without comment.

Where things stand

Area of agreement

Something your wife and the family have each said, separately, that turns out to match.

WRITE DOWN What matches, and who said it.

Unresolved difference

A place where two people want or expect different things. The Conversation Project says that finding out you disagree is OK, and that the important thing is to keep talking. [3]

WRITE DOWN Both positions, each in its owner's words. Don't settle it on paper.

Tradeoff

Two things that matter and may pull against each other. The same federal toolkit notes that some parts of our lives take priority over others at different times. [2]

WRITE DOWN The two things, as a subject to discuss. Not which one wins.

Question for a professional

Something the family can't answer by talking: a medical question for her doctor, or another question for the professional it belongs to.

WRITE DOWN The question, and who it goes to.

Decision criteria

What a family agrees a future choice would be measured against. This comes later, after these conversations, and isn't something to draft from this sheet.

WRITE DOWN Nothing yet. Keep the wishes, offers and open questions it will be built from.

Revisit

Coming back to what's written, because wishes and circumstances change. The Conversation Project's guide says nothing you say is permanent, and you can always change your mind as things change. [3]

WRITE DOWN When the two of you have agreed to look at it again.

What this sheet doesn't do

It names kinds of sentences. It doesn't say which wishes can be met, whether the family's offers are enough, or what anyone should decide.

Ready for the next step?

You can tell whose words are whose, and you know what to note under each. When you're both ready, the care interview sets what she and the family have said beside a full account of how she lives now, area by area, in a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
2. Administration for Community Living (National Center on Advancing Person-Centered Practices and Systems), Office of Healthcare Information and Counseling Person-Centered Thinking Toolkit
3. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement), Your Conversation Starter Guide: How to talk about what matters to you and have a say in your health care

4. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Person-Centered Care
5. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities

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